

Ravenloft: The Calling

Exclusive Preview

Prologue & Chapter One

K.G. Rhodes

Author of Gothic Dark Fantasy

Prologue

The night Aunt Maggie died, Ravenloft felt it first.

A tremor rippled through the old bones of the Manor, subtle enough that the lamps only flickered, but deep enough that every nail, every beam, every stone seemed tense. The house had been holding its breath for weeks, sensing the unraveling of the wards Maggie had woven into its walls.

Now the final thread snapped.

Maggie staggered in her study, one hand pressed to her chest, the other braced on the desk. The grimoire lay open before her, its pages glowing faintly with the last of her magic. The spell she had cast, her final protection, was incomplete. She knew she wouldn't finish it.

The shadow in the corner swelled, stretching long fingers across the floorboards.

"You're too late," Maggie whispered, though her voice was barely a breath. "They will come. The children will come."

The shadow surged.

The lamps blew out.

Ravenloft screamed.

Not aloud, its voice was older than sound, but the walls shuddered, the floorboards buckled, and every door in the house slammed shut at once. The Manor tried to push the darkness back, to shield her, to hold her upright.

But Maggie was already falling.

Her knees hit the floor. Her breath hitched. The grimoire slipped from her fingers and thudded onto the rug, pages fluttering wildly as if caught in a storm only it could feel.

The shadow reached for her.

Ravenloft struck back.

The chandelier above exploded in a burst of golden sparks, the wards flaring to life beneath the wallpaper like veins of molten light. The shadow recoiled with a soundless shriek, retreating into the cracks between the walls.

But Maggie did not see it.

Her eyes were already dimming.

With the last of her strength, she whispered to the house, "Hide it."

The grimoire snapped shut.

A gust of wind, impossible, indoor, fierce, swept through the study. Papers flew. Curtains whipped. The rug curled at the edges. The book slid across the floor as though pulled by invisible hands.

Ravenloft moved it.

The floorboards parted with a groan, revealing a narrow cavity beneath the desk. The book dropped into the darkness, landing with a soft, final thud.

The boards sealed themselves.

The rug smoothed.

The room stilled.

With her last breath, she looked at Ravenloft. "Find them. Return them...and their memories."

By the time Maggie's body slumped sideways, the grimoire was already gone, swallowed into the hidden places of the Manor where only the house itself could reach.

Outside, the wind returned in a violent rush, rattling the windows. The Raven on the chimney cawed once, sharp and mournful, before taking flight into the night.

When the neighbors found her the next morning, the study looked untouched.

No broken glass.

No scorch marks.

No sign of struggle.

No book.

Just Maggie, peaceful as if she had fallen asleep at her desk.

And Ravenloft, silent and watchful, guarding the secret she died to protect.

Chapter One

Ezra turned down the narrow dirt road as tangled wood pressed in from both sides, branches arching overhead like skeletal fingers trying to lace themselves together. The blue sky dimmed into a bruised purple as dusk settled, and the first stars blinked awake, tiny, cold witnesses to whatever waited ahead.

Ezra drummed his fingers on the steering wheel in time with the music, though the beat did not match the song at all.

“Dude,” Astrid muttered without looking up from Aunt Maggie’s letter, “you’re tapping like the rhythm personally offended you.”

“It did,” Ezra said. “This playlist is cursed.”

Astrid glanced up, unimpressed. “How is the playlist cursed? It just won’t play your favorite song on repeat?”

Ezra shot her a look. “Why do you keep reading that letter?”

Astrid’s eyes flicked back to the paper. “Because Aunt Maggie was in trouble, and I’m trying to figure out why.”

Ezra huffed. “I’ve read it. It doesn’t say.”

Astrid refolded the letter with a sharp crease. “Orion will be at the house. He’ll explain everything.” Symphony, curled in the back seat with her sketchbook and tarot cards, she didn’t look away from the window. “Everything is cursed,” she whispered, eyes wide as the trees seemed to lean closer. “Especially this road.”

The dirt path narrowed the farther they went, until it felt less like a road and more like a dare. Only one car could pass through at a time, and the pull-off spots looked like they’d been carved by someone who gave up halfway through.

“Great,” Astrid said, folding the letter again. “If we meet another car, we die.”

“Not necessarily,” Ezra replied. “We could also reverse for three miles in the dark while Symphony narrates our doom.”

Symphony didn’t blink. “I’m just saying the vibes are... splintery.”

“Splintery?” Ezra snorted. “What does that even”

They crested the final low hill.

And the house appeared.

It rose from the clearing like it had been waiting centuries for someone foolish enough to return. The wraparound porch sagged in places; its railings crooked like a tired smile. The windows reflected the last scraps of daylight, but something about them felt... aware. Watching. Deciding.

A single Raven sat on the chimney, staring directly at the car.

It cawed once.

Symphony whispered, "That's an omen."

Astrid whispered back, "Everything is an omen to you."

Ezra put the car in park and exhaled. "Well. Home sweet home!"

The porch light flickered on by itself.

No wind.

No motion sensor.

Just a slow, deliberate glow.

Symphony's tarot deck slid off her lap and scattered across the seat. The top card landed face-up.

The Tower.

They all stared at it "...Okay," Ezra said, forcing a grin. "So maybe the playlist wasn't the only cursed thing."

Symphony was looking out the window up at the house. It seemed to breathe; shutters creaked, and the porch sighed. A raven cawed from a dead branch overhead. Astrid jumped at the sudden sound, hand flying to her chest.

The engine ticked as it cooled, the only sound in the clearing besides the distant rustle of wind through the trees. Ezra opened his door first, mostly because he refused to admit he was nervous. The moment his foot hit the gravel, the porch light brightened, just a fraction, like the house was squinting at him.

"Okay," he muttered. "That's not creepy at all."

Astrid climbed out next, slamming her door with more force than necessary. The light on the porch flickered twice in response.

She froze.

"Did it just... sass me?"

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Symphony didn't get out right away. She sat in the back seat, clutching her sketchbook to her chest, staring at the house like it might lunge at them. When she finally stepped out, the wind shifted, carrying the faintest scent of lavender and old paper, Aunt Maggie's scent.

The porch light steadied.

Symphony whispered, "It likes me."

Ezra snorted. "It doesn't even know you."

"I think it does," answered Symphony.

The front door creaked open on its own.

Slowly.

Deliberately.

Like a butler who had been waiting far too long and was now judging their punctuality.

Astrid took a step back. “Nope. Absolutely not. Doors don’t open by themselves.”

“Maybe it’s on a timer,” Ezra said.

“There is no such thing as a door open timer.”

“Well, maybe there should be.”

Symphony drifted toward the gate, drawn in like a moth to a very haunted flame. “It’s inviting us.”

Ezra grabbed the back of her hoodie. “It’s inviting us to die.”

The Raven on the chimney cawed again, loud, sharp, impatient.

Astrid pointed at it. “See? Even the bird thinks we’re being dramatic.”

The porch boards creaked, though no one was standing on them. A slow, groaning sound, like the house was stretching after a long nap.

Then the front door

clicked.

Unlocked itself.

Ezra, Astrid, and Symphony stared at the door.

The door stared back. Or at least, it felt like it did.

“...Okay,” Ezra said, voice cracking just a little. “Show of hands. Who thinks Aunt Maggie forgot to mention the house is alive?”

Symphony raised her hand immediately.

Astrid raised hers after a beat.

Ezra sighed and raised his too. “Great. Democracy wins.”

A warm, golden glow spilled from the crack in the door, illuminating the porch like a welcome.

Or a lure.

Symphony whispered, “It wants us to come inside.”

Astrid whispered back, “Yeah, well, so did the witch’s cottage in Hansel and Gretel.”

Ezra squared his shoulders, trying to look braver than he felt. “Alright. We go in together. No splitting up. No wandering off. No touching anything that looks like it might curse us.”

Symphony blinked. “That’s everything in the house.”

“Exactly.”

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They stepped toward the porch.

The house is exhaled soft, wooden, ancient.

Not a creak.

Not a groan.

A breath.

Symphony felt it first.

A pull, subtle but insistent, tugged at the back of her mind.

A shift in the air, like the house had turned its attention directly on her.

Something brushed the inside of her skull, like fingertips trailing across fogged glass.

Symphony stopped short, breath catching. Ezra slowed a step ahead of her, brow furrowing, and Astrid's hand drifted to her chest as if she'd been struck by the same invisible thread.

The air thickened around them, warm and familiar in a way that made no sense.

"This all feels familiar," Symphony whispered. "But I don't know why."

Ezra nodded slowly. "Yeah. Like we've been here before."

Astrid swallowed. "We have. I can feel it. But the memories are... hiding."

And they were.

Not gone.

Not erased.

Just tucked away, like someone had folded them neatly and placed them in a drawer they weren't meant to open yet.

The porch boards warmed beneath their feet, the air thickening as if the house leaned closer, listening, remembering, choosing.

Symphony's pulse stuttered.

Ezra's breath hitched.

Astrid's fingers curled tight around her bag.

Something waited on the other side of that door.

Something old.

Something that knew them.

The hinges whispered.

And the door began to open.

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The door opened wider. A middle-aged man stepped into the doorway as though the house itself had summoned him. Orion Lockwood, Aunt Maggie's oldest friend, the family's quiet anchor, stood framed in the flickering porch light, his black suit catching the glow like a shadow given shape.

He didn't look surprised to see them.

He looked... relieved.

As if their arrival had been a long-delayed inevitability.

“Ezra. Symphony. Astrid,” he said, voice low and steady. “Welcome back to Ravenloft.”

Behind him, the house exhaled again, soft, deliberate, unmistakably alive.

He had known Ezra, Astrid, and Symphony their entire lives, long before tragedy touched the family. He’d been there for birthdays, scraped knees, awkward teenage summers, and every visit the siblings made to Ravenloft. And after their parents died just a year ago, he became the steady presence who helped them navigate the grief they still didn’t quite know how to carry.

Orion’s black suit was crisp despite the dust of the long road, and his black hair, grey at the temples, was pulled back in a low ponytail, giving him the look of someone who belonged equally in an old portrait and the present moment. Up close, the details sharpened: the faint silver threading through his beard, the storm-grey eyes that had watched them grow from children chasing fireflies on Ravenloft’s lawn to the wary adults standing before him now, and the quiet vigilance in the way he held himself.

There was something almost ceremonial about his arrival, as though he hadn’t simply stepped out of the house but emerged from it, woven into its history, its secrets, its memory. The porch light flickered once, as if greeting him.

He gave them a small, knowing smile.

Not warm. Not cold.

Just... steady. The kind of smile he said he remembered every summer they’d ever spent here and knew exactly why this return felt different.

Orion knew the siblings didn’t remember their trips here. Their aunt had always spelled them with a memory block, mostly to keep them safe from the darkness that looked for them.

He smiled as he walked toward them, the porch light brightening as if pleased to see him.

“Ezra, Symphony, Astrid. I’m so glad you could make it up here.”

Ezra shook his hand, and Orion pulled the girls into warm, familiar hugs. Symphony stiffened at first, she always did, but then relaxed when she caught the faint scent of cedar and old books clinging to him.

“I’m deeply sorry for the loss of your aunt,” Orion said softly.

Ezra nodded. “It’s been a long time since we’ve seen you as well. I’m sorry for your loss, too. I know you and Aunt Maggie were close.”

Orion’s smile faltered, just for a heartbeat. “We were. And I am so sorry it took so long to contact you. Every time I sent a letter, it was returned.”

Ezra frowned. “Why didn’t you call?”

“I tried,” Orion said, rubbing the back of his neck. “But the numbers kept coming up disconnected.”

“That’s... weird,” Ezra muttered.

“Very weird,” Astrid echoed.

Symphony whispered, “Splintery vibes.”

Ezra sighed. “Please stop saying that.”

“But you’re here now,” Orion said, gently redirecting them. “Come on in. I’m sure you’re tired from your trip.”

Ezra opened the back of the SUV, and they each grabbed their luggage. The moment Symphony stepped onto the porch, the shadows shifted, subtle, but unmistakable. They curled around her feet like curious cats, and the wooden boards beneath her seemed to inhale.

She froze.

“Did the house just... breathe?” she whispered.

Astrid stepped beside her. “Maybe it’s settling.”

“It’s settling on purpose,” Symphony said.

Ezra, halfway up the steps, muttered, “Everything is on purpose with this place.”

As Symphony crossed the threshold, faint whispering rose around her, soft, overlapping voices, like pages turning in a dozen rooms at once. She spun, trying to find the source, but the whispers came from everywhere and nowhere.

Inside, Orion paused mid-stride.

The front door shut behind them with a weight that felt final.

Ezra didn’t wait to see if it would open again. His hand came up automatically palm hovering near the wall as he scanned the entryway, stairs, shadows, the long corridor vanishing into the dark. The air was warmer near the floor, colder at shoulder height. Unstable. Stay here he said, already stepping forward. Ezra. I just want eyes on the corners.

The chandelier above them flickered light stuttering like a held breath. Astrid followed it with her gaze instead of him. The glass hadn’t swayed. No draft. Yet the wards beneath the wallpaper faint almost invisible were flexing. Responding.

Symphony hadn’t moved at all. Her fingers brushed the banister, and she inhaled sharply, not in fear but in recognition. The wood was humming. Not audibly, exactly, but present. The sound wasn’t in the room it was in her chest.

“It knows we’re here,” she said. Ezra stopped “What”?

The house settled around them, boards popping once, then stilling. The front door’s lock slid home with a soft deliberate click.

Astrid stomach tightened. That wasn’t just structural response, she said. That was intentional.

Symphony finished, her voice barely above a whisper. It’s been waiting.

Ezra turned back then, firelight flickering briefly in his eyes before he dragged it down, buried it. He planted his feet wider, as if daring the house to test him.

Fine he said If this place wants our attention, it has it.

The foyer warmed up. The lights steadied. Astrid swallowed. Symphony closed her eyes.

Ravenloft listened.

That's Maggie's work, she said calmly. Or what's left of it.

He turned back to Symphony, his expression unreadable but not surprised. "Ah," he said. "..."she remembers.

Ezra blinked. "The house remembers?"

Orion gestured them further inside. "Come in, all of you. Ravenloft has been waiting a long time."

The door closed behind them with a soft, decisive click.

The siblings jumped.

Orion smiled faintly. "Don't worry. It only locks people out. Not in."

Ezra stared at him. "That's... not comforting."

"Good," Orion said. "You shouldn't be comforted yet."

The foyer of Ravenloft Manor stretched out before them, tall ceilings, dark wood, a chandelier that glimmered like it remembered better centuries. The air felt thick, charged, as if the house were holding its breath.

Continue the Journey...

Thank you for visiting Ravenloft Manor.

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